Warner Center - Can futuristic Urban Movement Labs help? - $2 million will be spent to to help bring autonomous vehicles to local area

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State Assembly member Jesse Gabriel (D-Woodland Hills) presented a “novelty check” to the West Valley Warner Center Chamber of Commerce on Tuesday, symbolizing $2 million from the State of California budget that could, among other things, help bring autonomous vehicles to Warner Center.

The tongue-twisting Transportation Technology Infrastructure and Innovation Zone (TTIIZ), is, according to Gabriel’s team, a first-of-its-kind center to support cutting-edge transportation and mobility technology. The state funds will go to Urban Movement Labs, a public entity that aims to launch “innovative transportation technologies” that will be applied to the Warner Center area.

A key goal of Urban Movement Labs is to address what Gabriel’s office called “the ever-present first-mile/last-mile challenge” — meaning the long distances between the end of a transit line and the home, or job, that a transit rider is heading for.

The pilot programs will include the use of electric vehicles with the intent of later on “transitioning to an autonomous vehicle program, as soon as infrastructure and technology allow” for it, Gabriel’s office said.

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